SPANISH WARS

THE DUTCH REVOLT of 1568 against the rule of Spanish Catholic king, Philip II, started a war that would last for 80 years. With William of Nassau, Prince of Orange, as their leader, the Dutch fought a desperate struggle for survival against the might of Spain, greatly aided by the skill and courage of their sailors, whose small ships fought a seaborne guerrilla campaign against Spanish naval might. The English queen, Elizabeth I, tried to avoid war with Spain, but she could not resist backing privateers preying on Spanish colonies in the New World. England was also drawn into support for the Dutch rebels. By 1585 Philip had decided that the heretical English queen must be subdued. Victory over French-backed mercenaries in the Azores in 1583 encouraged him to believe that he could defeat the English navy with an oceanic fleet. The Spanish Armada operation of 1588, intended to allow an invasion of England by Spanish troops from the Netherlands, was an ambitious but ill-conceived exercise in the use of naval power. The skill and courage of English sailors ensured its failure, although the subsequent destruction of the Armada by storms was fortuitous.

ENGLISH PRIVATEERING EXPEDITION

SAN JUAN DE ULÚA



Date September 24, 1569
Forces English: 5 ships; Spanish: 13 ships
Losses English: 3 ships captured: Spanish: none

Location Veracruz, New Spain (Mexico)

After two years' illegal trading and piracy around the coasts of Spain's American colonies, in September 1569 English privateer John Hawkins and his cousin Francis Drake entered the port of Veracruz, with the reluctant permission of the Spanish authorities. They were anchored in the harbor off San Juan de Ulúa island when a fleet from Spain arrived, bringing a new viceroy. At first the viceroy pretended to accept the English presence, but on September 24 he ordered a surprise night attack. Hawkins and Drake escaped on board two small ships, *Minion* and *Judith*. After much hardship, they reached home the following year.

DUTCH REVOLT

ZUIDERZEE



Date October 5–12, 1573
Forces Spanish: 18 ships; Dutch: 24 ships
Losses Spanish: 6 ships captured; Dutch: none

Location Zuiderzee, near Hoorn, Netherlands

In 1569 William of Nassau, Prince of Orange, issued letters of marque to a motley assembly of sea captains prepared to offer their services to the Dutch revolt. As the rebels in the Netherlands had adopted the ironic nickname of "the Beggars," these privateers became known as the Sea Beggars. Operating out of safe havens provided by the Protestant French in La Rochelle and by Queen Elizabeth in southern England, they raided the Netherlands coast and inhibited the seaborne trade of the Spanish-ruled provinces. The Sea Beggars' indiscriminate plunder of merchant shipping led Elizabeth to ban them from English ports in spring 1572, whereupon they seized new bases on the Dutch coast.

The Spanish fought back and in the summer of 1573 retook the rebel city of Haarlem. They then planned to regain control of the Zuiderzee, the inland water between Spanish-held Amsterdam and the North Sea. Maximilien de Henin, Count of Bossu, assembled a war fleet at Amsterdam. In October he sailed out aboard his provocatively named 34-gun flagship, *Inquisition*. The Sea Beggars emerged from their bases around the Zuiderzee to give battle, with Cornelis Dirkszoon, mayor of Monnickendam, in command.

The Spanish were superior in firepower, but Dirkszoon hoped to close with them with his smaller ships and take them by boarding. The first encounter, on October 5, went badly for the Sea Beggars. In adverse winds they were unable to board the enemy ships and suffered heavily from cannon fire. There followed a standoff until October 11, when the wind shifted in Dirkszoon's favor. His ships bore down upon the Spanish, three of them engaging *Inquisition*, which ran aground on a sandbank. The fighting was fierce. Dirkszoon was wounded, command passing to his captain Jan Floor. Several Spanish ships were taken, while the rest fled back to Amsterdam. *Inquisition* held out the longest but was captured after more than 24 hours' combat. Bossu was among those taken prisoner.

Sea Beggars in action
The Sea Beggars make a surprise landing in a coastal town, putting the Spanish and the Catholics among the local residents to flight.

